

Alexus Adkins

Dr. Alisa Clapp-Itnyre

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Queerness Made Visible: How Victorian Poets Disguised Queerness

Victorian society was very strict about gender roles, sexuality, and morality. This made it difficult to openly express same-sex desire. Queer relationships were not something that was usually spoken about directly and they were often treated as something “unspeakable,” which means that they had to be discreet and hide their relationships or desires. Instead of disappearing, queer desire showed up in indirect and coded ways, especially in literature. This pressure is reflected in queer Victorian poetry as poets were able to find creative ways to express their desires while still following social rules. Since they could not openly discuss queer themes, they used different strategies to disguise it. These include showing deep emotional bonds between men, using metaphor and physical intimacy to suggest desire, and placing queer relationships in a different setting where they would feel less controversial. The tension between being able to express yourself and having to hide who you are is especially visible in Alexander Smith’s *A Life-Drama* (1853), particularly in “Forerunners” and “To ----,” Christina Rossetti’s *Goblin Market* (1859), and Michael Field’s *Long Ago* (1889), especially in “Adown the Lesbian vales” and “Atthis, my darling, thou did’st stray.” Each of these pieces show strong emotional connections, as well as physical, that challenge the norms of Victorian societal expectations. However, each of these stories hides their queerness in different ways. In this essay, I will argue that Alexander Smith, Christina Rossetti, and Michael Field all disguise queer desire through

literary strategies, but they differ in how they manage this. Smith does this through showing a deep emotional bond between two men and redirects it within something socially acceptable. Rossetti uses metaphor, physical intimacy, and a moral framework to disguise queer desire. Field takes an entirely different approach and by avoiding Victorian society and expressing queer desire in a society where it can exist more freely.

For cultural context, Victorian society was deeply invested in controlling what could and could not be spoken of, especially when it came to taboo topics like sexuality. One of the most important concepts for understanding this cultural setting is what is described as “the unspeakable.” This term is used to refer to things that were not to be said, as well as things that are socially unacceptable, such as same-sex attraction (McGuire 44). Even when queer men were on trial for homosexual acts, the term “homosexual was avoided and replaced with words like “unnatural” and “infamous.” This was done in an attempt to stop queerness from spreading. Something important mentioned in this text is that the censorship of queerness did not get rid of it, but instead created “other, richer languages of description” (McGuire 45). This means that instead of disappearing, queer desire was expressed in indirect ways, such as metaphor, coded language, and imagery. Since people could not speak openly about same-sex relationships, they found alternative ways to represent those feelings. As a result, poetry created by queer Victorian poets often have encoded forms of queerness that must be read carefully in order to be fully understood. In addition to this, the legal system reinforced this by creating an environment for silence and fear. This was done through the Buggery Act of 1553, and later the Offences against the Person Act of 1861. The Buggery Act is when sodomy was defined under law as “the detestable and abominable vice of buggery” and the punishment was death. The Offences against the Person Act reduced this punishment from death to life imprisonment. It was difficult to

convict under these as penetration had to be proven. However, this was changed with Section 11 of the Criminal Law Amendment Act 1885, also known as the Labouchere Amendment. This amendment criminalized “gross indecency” between men. Unlike the earlier laws, this amendment allowed the prosecution of male homosexuals even when sodomy could not be proven. Since this law was easier to enforce, it increased the danger of male same-sex desire and further pressured queer men into secrecy (“Labouchere Amendment”). This legal and cultural context helps explain why Victorian poets relied so heavily on coded language and disguise. Open expressions of queer desire carried not only social stigma but also the threat of imprisonment, making same-sex desire something that could not safely be shared with the outside world. Instead, their desires became something that could appear on page after being translated into safer words and forms. In this way, the disguise was not just a limitation but also a creative strategy that allowed poets to express what could not be openly said while still staying within the boundaries of Victorian society.

In Alexander Smith’s *A-Life Drama* (1853), queer desire is expressed through intense connections between men. However, it is carefully framed to make it feel socially acceptable. Smith’s background helps to explain why his poetry often focuses on emotional expression and unconventional relationships. Born in 1829 into a working-class Scottish family, he left school at only eleven years old to work in a textile factory with his father. Later, he educated himself in literature and became published in working-class journals before becoming successful in the literary field. Despite the homoerotic undertones that can be identified in his poetry, Smith married Flora MacDonald, a woman, in 1857, maintaining the appearance of the conventional Victorian domestic life. (Scottish Poetry Library). This background helps to explain why his poetry is deeply emotional while putting less emphasis on strict structures. Instead, he has chosen

to prioritize feelings and connections. In *A Life-Drama*, this pattern becomes clear through the way Smith develops emotional and physical closeness between men while framing it as artistic connection. A major aspect of what makes poetry so beautiful is that it can remain gender-neutral because terms like “I” and “you” can represent many kinds of relationships. This flexibility allows for emotional intimacy within poems without forcing it into one clear interpretation.

This pattern is mostly seen in “Forerunners.” For Victorian readers, the use of “he” and “I” could still be interpreted in ways that made the poem socially acceptable because emotional admiration between men could be dismissed as artistic or intellectual connection rather than romantic desire. However, the emotional intensity here suggests that the relationship should instead be read as one between men that carries queer love. This is seen in the quote, “He was the sun, I was that squab—the earth / And bask’d me in his light until he drew” (Alexander lines 10-11). This is a metaphor that positions the man the speaker is describing as something that provides light and life to him. This speaker is not simply admiring this man but is depending on him for sustenance. This is intensified by the next lines that say, “And I rejoiced upon his shore of pearls / A weak enamor’d sea” (Alexander lines 13-14). These lines portray the speaker as overwhelmed and drawn toward the other man, much like the tide is pulled toward the shore. In this section, the word “enamor’d” is important as it is usually used to describe romantic or emotional attraction. Smith could have chosen to describe this relationship as one of mentorship or admiration, but instead he uses language that suggests longing and attachment. In that choice, he is showing that queerness is present, even if it is not directly stated. This idea continues in moments of physical interaction, such as when the speaker says, “He grasp’d my hand, — I look’d upon his face, — / A thought struck all the blood into his cheeks / Like a strong buffet. His great flashing eyes / Burn’d on mine own” (Smith, lines 45–48). This scene emphasizes

touch and keeping eye contact, which are often associated with romantic or emotional intensity. However, because the interaction occurs within a discussion of poetry and artistic ambition, it is again redirected into a safer, more socially acceptable form. The relationship presented here is hidden beneath the language of artistic inspiration and mentorship rather than openly presented as romantic love. Smith disguises these emotions within discussions of poetry, intellect, and admiration because those subjects were considered acceptable ways for Victorian men to express deep feeling toward one another. Through these choices, Smith is presenting queer desire as something that is felt deeply while still being carefully hidden within poetic expression. This reflects the Victorian cultural idea of the “unspeakable,” where same-sex desire could not be openly discussed and instead had to be expressed indirectly through coded language and emotional intensity rather than active acknowledgment.

Another poem from *A Life-Drama* where this is present is in “To ----.” In this poem, Smith develops an emotionally intense relationship that feels romantic while still remaining ambiguous enough to avoid directly acknowledging it. This is first seen in the lines, “And I lay at thy feet / You bent above me” (Smith lines 2-3). These lines immediately establish that there is a power imbalance between the speaker and the subject. The speaker has placed himself physically beneath the other person, creating a feeling of devotion and emotional surrender. Instead of presenting the relationship as simple admiration, Smith frames it as something deeply consuming for the speaker. Also, this emotional dependence becomes stronger in later lines. An example of this is where it says, “You kiss’d me then, I worshipp’d at thy feet / Upon the shadowy sod” (Smith lines 9-10). These lines depict a kiss that introduces physical intimacy, while the word “worshipp’d” turns the relationship into something sacred and obsessive. The speaker of this poem is not simply expressing affection but treating the subject as someone worthy of their

complete devotion. Through this language, Smith creates a connection that carries romantic and potentially queer undertones. Another example of this coded intimacy is in the lines, “But clung around me as the woodbine frail / Clings, pleading, round an oak” (Smith lines 27-28). In this, the subject is being compared to a vine wrapping itself around a tree for support. The is used to emphasize the closeness and emotional dependency they have created together as the subject is portrayed as being unable to separate himself from the speaker. The word “pleading” adds another layer of vulnerability as it suggests a fear of abandonment and emotional desperation. At the same time, this metaphor complicates traditional Victorian gender expectations as this relationship is built on tenderness and emotional openness rather than masculine restraint. This connects to Linda Hughes’s argument in ‘Alexander Smith and the Bisexual Poetics of ‘A Life-Drama.’” Here, she says, “Another recurring pattern in keeping with the poem’s bisexual imagination – feminized men and masculinized women -- likewise troubles gender binaries” (Hughes 498). This point is important because the emotional dynamics in the poem do not fit into the Victorian ideals of traditional masculine and feminine roles. Also, Hughes explains that “What is less rarely noted is the lines’ bisexual context: they are spoken by the male poet to the woman he loves, but they recount the origin of his poetics in male-male desire and intimacy” (Hughes 498). This helps to connect “Forerunners” and “To ----” as both poems blur the line between heterosexual and homoerotic expressions. Even when Smith appears to present conventional romantic love, you can feel traces of same-sex intimacy within the emotional structure of the poems. Through emotional intensity, physical closeness, and coded language, Smith presents queer desire as something deeply felt while still being hidden within acceptable Victorian poetic expression.

While Smith hides queer desire within male artistic relationships, Christina Rossetti's story titled, "Goblin Market" from *Goblin Market and Other Poems* (1862) highlights a complex example of disguised queerness in Victorian poetry as she uses metaphor and intense physical intimacy between women to express desire that cannot be directly discussed. Rossetti's history helps to explain this indirect approach. Born in 1830 into a well-known family of artists, she was deeply influenced by religion and the High-Church, or Anglo-Catholic, tradition. In addition to this, she had a strong commitment to moral and spiritual values that led her to never get married, despite multiple proposals ("Christina Rossetti"). This tension between religious devotion and emotional intensity has a strong impact on "Goblin Market" as desire is expressed but contained within Rossetti's moral boundaries. In "Goblin Market," Rossetti presents a poem that originally feels like a moral cautionary tale about temptation and redemption, but it carefully disguises queer desire within the relationship between Lizzie and Laura by displaying their intimacy in a socially acceptable way as sisters. While the poem seems to focus on warning against being unable to control yourself, its most emotionally intense moments focus on the deep physical and emotional bond between the women over the punishment itself as the emotional bond between the "sisters" becomes more central than the poem's moral lesson. Due to this, their relationship can be read with the suggestion of queer desire hidden beneath the acceptable language of familial love. From the beginning of this poem, Rossetti has emphasized the physical closeness between Lizzie and Laura in ways that blur the line between sisterhood and romantic intimacy. Early in the poem, Rossetti writes, "Laura bow'd her head to hear, / Lizzie veil'd her blushes / Crouching close together / In the cooling weather, / With clasping arms and cautioning lips, / With tingling cheeks and finger tips" (Rossetti lines 34-39). The language used here, such as, "blushes," "clasping arms," and "tingling cheeks and finger tips," helps to create an atmosphere

of intimacy between the “sisters” before the goblin men even appear as a threat. Rossetti continues this imagery later when she describes the sisters sleeping “Golden head by golden head, / Like two pigeons in one nest... / Cheek to cheek and breast to breast / Lock'd together in one nest” (Rossetti lines 184-185; 197-198). By repeatedly emphasizing how their bodies are intertwined, Rossetti makes Lizzie and Laura feel as though they are mirroring each other, and their emotional and physical closeness becomes one of the poem’s main focuses. Although the language can be read as them just being two sisters who are very affectionate, physical imagery suggests a deeper form of desire hidden beneath socially acceptable familial language. This becomes clear when Lizzie chooses to risk her own life in order to save Laura’s life. After Laura becomes unwell after eating the fruit, Lizzie walks straight into danger by going to the goblins who hurt Laura and allows herself to suffer their violence if it means helping Laura. In the poem, it says, “Claw'd with their nails / Barking, mewling, hissing, mocking / Tore her gown and soil'd her stocking... / Held her hands and squeez'd their fruits / Against her mouth to make her eat” (Rossetti lines 401-403; 406-407). This scene highlights not only Lizzie’s physical suffering and can be read as an act of sexual violence. However, Lizzie does not back down. Shortly after this, it says, “Though the goblins cuff'd and caught her... / Would not open lip from lip / Lest they should cram a mouthful in” (Rossetti lines 424; 431-432). Her refusal to open her mouth becomes a powerful statement of bodily autonomy. Even while being attacked, she maintains control over her own body, resisting the goblins’ attempts to force “the fruit” upon her and receiving the cure to save Laura. Her resistance to the goblin’s violence and losing her bodily autonomy is important when Lizzie returns to save Laura. This is because Lizzie is no longer controlled by them, meaning that she can choose how her body is used. In an act of regaining her autonomy, she offers herself willingly to Laura, becoming the source of healing rather than a

victim of coercion. When she tells Laura to “Come and kiss me / Never mind my bruises / Hug me, kiss me, suck my juices,” she is shifting the moment from one of forced contact to one of chosen intimacy (Rossetti lines 466-468). Lizzie’s body, once under threat, is now something she willingly shares. This transforms the earlier violence they have experienced into an act of care, closeness, and emotional connection between the women. Also, the intimacy of this moment reflects back to the earlier scenes of physical closeness between the sisters. Rossetti has repeatedly presented Lizzie and Laura as emotionally inseparable and physically intertwined, which makes the rescue scene feel less like ordinary familial affection and more like an intense emotional union between the women. Despite the seemingly clear queerness of this exchange, Rossetti hides the queer aspects behind the guise of “sisterhood.” As mentioned, Lizzie and Laura are referred to as “sisters.” However, since Lizzie and Laura are being represented as sisters, it makes their intimacy more socially acceptable for a Victorian audience, even if the poem’s language is blatant in portraying something more. This is evident as it says, “She clung about her sister” (Rossetti line 485). However, this line is followed up with, “Kiss'd and kiss'd and kiss'd her / She kiss'd and kiss'd her with a hungry mouth” (Rossetti lines 486; 492). The contrast between these lines is important because the label “sister” suggests a socially acceptable, non-romantic relationship, while the repeated kissing and the phrase “hungry mouth” express a level of physical intensity that goes beyond typical familial affection. At the same time, Rossetti decides to end the poem by placing Lizzie and Laura within heterosexual marriages. This helps to contain and redirect their earlier intimacy into a socially acceptable conclusion. This ending allows the poem to maintain Victorian moral expectations on the outside while still leaving space for the earlier scenes of desire between the sisters to carry queer implications. In Lorraine Janzen Kooistra’s piece titled, “Modern Markets for ‘Goblin Market,’” she explains that Victorian

readers were divided over whether the poem should be interpreted as a moral allegory warning against temptation or as a sensual celebration of desire. She does this by discussing how illustrations connected to the poem emphasized both morality and female intimacy. Kooistra argues that some illustrations transformed the sisters into “mirrored doubles” whose physical closeness and similarity shifted attention away from “the moral story with sexual fantasy” (Kooistra 253). This connects to Rossetti’s use of sisterhood in the poem because Lizzie and Laura’s identity as sisters helps disguise their intimacy beneath a socially acceptable relationship, even while the poem repeatedly emphasizes their emotional and psychical closeness. This allows for queer desire to be disguised in this poem as calling them “sisters” would have been beneficial in providing Victorian society with a socially acceptable relationship while still allowing space for a deeper meaning. The emotional and physical closeness between Lizzie and Laura becomes the center of the poem, but it is framed in a way that avoids direct confrontation with Victorian norms. This reflects the Victorian idea of the “unspeakable.” Not just because it is an example of how queer desire is hidden, but also because it is being used in a socially acceptable way. Instead of being directly expressed, it appears through the language of sisterhood and moral sacrifice, which allows the poem to present intense intimacy between women without openly challenging Victorian norms.

Michael Field’s *Long Ago* (1889) depicts a dramatic shift from the earlier strategies of disguising queerness as it does not attempt to hide the desire but instead relocates it outside of Victorian society altogether. Understanding this approach requires attention to the authors’ background. “Michael Field” is the pseudonym used by both Katharine Bradley and Edith Cooper. These two women were not just collaborators, but were also aunt and niece, as well as lovers who wrote together as one poetic voice. They published under a male name to gain respect

in a literary culture that often dismissed female writers and to more freely express love for women (Kersch, Bryant, and Burke). In addition to this, Bradley and Cooper were heavily influenced by the Aesthetic Movement and by ancient Greek culture. Their fascination with Greek and Roman literature eventually led them to convert to a form of paganism that is centered around Dionysus, the Greek god associated with pleasure, fertility, music, and feminine power. By turning toward ancient Greece, mythology, and the poetry of Sappho, they created a literary space removed from expectations and restrictions of Victorian life. This connection to Hellenic culture became one of the most distinctive aspects of Michael Field's aestheticism because it allowed them to express queer desire and fluid identities more openly than would have been acceptable in contemporary Victorian society (Columbo). Some other poems from *Long Ago* that reflect queer coded, classical themes include "Climbing the hill a coil of snakes," "When longing on my couch I lay," "I sang to women gathered round," and "Not Gello's self loves more than I." This background is crucial because it explains why their poetry does not merely disguise queerness within Victorian society but instead actively avoids that society.

In "Adown the Lesbian vales" from *Long Ago*, it expands this strategy by depicting a community of women who do not shy away from queerness. This poem opens with a scene of communal female activity. This says, "I watch the lovely rout / Of maidens flitting 'mid the honey-bees" (Field lines 3-4). This context is important as it establishes that this is an all-female environment where the presence of men is not seen. The speaker's role within this community is that of both an observer and a participant. As the poem continues, it uses imagery to emphasize sensory pleasure and intimacy. An example of this is when it says, "So fresh as they / When on my breast / They lean, and say / All that they would" (Field lines 23-26). This scene highlights the physical and emotional closeness between the women, as the act of leaning on the speaker's

body displays the physical and the way they speak to each other freely displays the emotional. This creates a moment where closeness and desire are shown as natural and unrestricted. This can be compared to the way intimacy is portrayed in “Goblin Market” as this version of intimacy is seen as unproblematic and ordinary, while the intimacy in “Goblin Market” was within the context of temptation, punishment, and redemption. Even when the poem discusses marriage, it continues to center the relationships between women. In the last stanza, it says, “To that pure band alone / I sing of marriage-loves” (Field lines 28-29). This shows that marriage is not depicted as a heterosexual institution like it would have been in the Victorian era. Instead, it is something that is understood and performed inside of this community of women. Shortly after this, it says, “No girls let fall / Their maiden zone / At Hymen's call” (Field lines 32-34). These lines are interesting as they suggest that even traditional structures have been reimagined in this community through a female-centered perspective. This poem’s depiction of queerness was made possible due to how it has separated itself from the Victorian setting and their values, placing it in ancient Greece instead. This allowed Field to avoid the strictness of Victorian society that made queer desire “unspeakable” as they created a setting where queerness is seen as normal.

Another Michael Field poem that further removes queer desire from Victorian society is “Atthis, my darling, thou did’st stray.” Instead of coding intimacy between women within Victorian society, the poem places its relationship within the distant world of ancient Greece and Sapphic tradition. This is evident by the use of the name “Atthis,” which comes from the poetry of Sappho (Burch). This immediately separates the poem from Victorian culture and relocates it into a classical environment where queer desire can be expressed more openly. This distancing is important because it allows the poem to avoid the moral expectations and restrictions of Victorian Era England. From the opening lines, the poem centers entirely on emotional devotion

between women without introducing heterosexual relationships or moral judgment. The speaker says, “When a great fear and passion shook / My heart lest haply thou wert dead” (Field lines 3-4). These lines show that the speaker is experiencing emotional distress at the thought of losing another woman, emphasizing the depth and intensity of their connection. The pairing of “fear and passion” suggests that the relationship is both emotional and romantic rather than simply friendly. However, the poem does not frame these feelings as shameful or inappropriate. Instead, their intimacy is treated as natural within the poem’s classical setting. This showcases how different Field’s poetry is from other Victorian texts that often redirect queer desire and intimacy back into heterosexual endings, such as “Goblin Market,” as this poem remains focused solely on the relationship between the two women. Also, this poem openly places emphasis on the physical closeness between the women. After the lover returns, the speaker says, “Away, away, the flowers I flung / And thee down to my breast I drew” (Field lines 11-12). This moment is prioritizing physical intimacy over symbolic gestures because the flowers immediately become less important than direct physical contact. The final stanza continues this closeness when the speaker declares, “Queen Dawn shall find us on one bed” (Field line 15). This shows that rather than presenting queer intimacy as shameful or forbidden, the poem normalizes it within its detached and idealized world. By removing the relationship from recognizable Victorian social life, the poem creates a space where queer desire can be expressed openly instead of remaining “unspeakable.” These poems reflect the cultural idea of the “unspeakable” in a different way than Smith or Rossetti, because instead of disguising queer desire within Victorian principles, Field avoids those principles all together. In doing this, these poems show that queer desire does not need to be hidden. In fact, it only becomes “unspeakable” when it is placed within restrictive social conditions, like those of Victorian society.

When viewed together, Alexander Smith, Christina Rossetti, and Michael Field all show that queer desire was a real thing within Victorian literature and society, but they respond to its presence different ways. Smith disguises queerness by placing queer desire within strong male friendships and emotional connections that feel socially acceptable when viewed on the surface level. Similarly, Rossetti disguises queer desire by using metaphor, physical intimacy, and the "sisterhood" to disguise desire in a way that appears moral and acceptable to Victorian standards. Going in a different direction as Smith and Rossetti, Field chose to express queer desire more openly by placing it in distant historical and mythic setting that allowed queerness to be explored with less immediate social risk within Victorian society. These differences matter as they show that queer desire was not absent from Victorian literature but instead required different strategies in order to be expressed safely within the era they were living in. Ultimately, these poets are not simply hiding queerness. They are revealing how Victorian poetry became a safe space when queer desire could survive by changing its language, form, and setting.

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